

THE PHOENIX COMMUNITY TRUST

Strategy Development Partner Commission

Invitation to Tender

1. About This Document

This document is the invitation to tender for [The Phoenix Community Trust's](#) strategy development commission. It sets out the full scope of the work, what Phoenix is looking for in a partner, the assessment process, and how to submit. It will be published as part of an open procurement process.

2. About The Phoenix Community Trust

The Phoenix Community Trust is a newly established organisation working in the fields of racial justice, community power and social change. It operates at the intersection of grassroots community infrastructure and the philanthropic landscape, with a national footprint across nine regions in England.

The Phoenix Community Trust emerged as a community-led response to the structural inequalities confronting Global Majority communities in the UK.

In 2020, in the midst of the COVID-19 pandemic, the Phoenix Fund mobilised emergency funding support for grassroots groups, getting resources to communities at pace, when they were needed most.

As the work grew, in 2021 partners came together as The Phoenix Way Partnership, with a shared ambition to dismantle systemic racism in philanthropy and drive lasting, community-led, transformative change.

A new chapter began in 2025 when Phoenix was incorporated as an independent Global Majority-led organisation, with a newly appointed independent Board, to steward the next phase of the work. The new structure lays the foundation for long-term investment in community infrastructure and the development of a lasting model for change.

Today, we honour the roots of The Phoenix Community Trust (TPCT) and the communities, partners and funders who shaped its early momentum, while looking forward with renewed energy and excitement to what comes next.

TPCT is now in an active transition phase: building its identity, its team and its relationships. The strategy development process is one of the first and most significant acts of the organisation, a public commitment to convening, listening and defining its future direction with the communities and partners it exists to serve.

TPCT has been awarded £50m award from The National Lottery Community Fund (TNLCF), combining capacity building, direct financial investment, and infrastructure development for the Global Majority and

Black, Racialised and Minoritised (BRM) VCSE sector. The strategy to be developed will deploy this award, though it is intended to be broader in scope than the grant alone: TPCT aims to establish a permanent endowment and build an enduring organisation beyond the funding period.

3. Purpose of the Commission

TPCT is seeking an external partner to lead a comprehensive, participatory strategy development process, resulting in a final strategy framework that the incoming Chief Executive and team can operationalise.

The process must be genuinely participatory, not a consultation exercise that arrives at a pre-determined conclusion. Genuine participation means people have a real say and a real dialogue, not simply an opportunity to submit views that are collected and filed away. It does not require unanimous agreement, or that every view raised is adopted, but it does require a clear and transparent commitment to reflect back what has been heard, what TPCT has understood by it, and what has been decided as a result, and why. Providers should build this feedback loop, sometimes described as “you said, we heard, here’s what we did”, into their methodology from the outset.

The commissioned partner will be the first meaningful outward representation of TPCT with grassroots partners and communities. Their understanding of anti-racist practice, and their ability to work with authenticity and nuance, is critical. This goes beyond general diversity, equity and inclusion experience: providers should be able to demonstrate an understanding of how power and oppression operate structurally and institutionally, including within funder and philanthropic relationships, and how that understanding shapes the way they design and deliver community engagement. A provider that is not able to evidence this, or that approaches this as a standard consultancy commission, will undermine the process before it begins.

Engagement should be framed around TPCT's future direction and the legacy it is trying to build, not primarily around the availability of funding. Providers should be alert to, and actively manage, the risk that focus on the available £50m award narrows or distorts the conversation.

4. Scope and Deliverables

4.1 Roles and Responsibilities

We anticipate the following key roles and responsibilities for the strategy development activity:

- **TPCT Trustees:** Responsible for commissioning and overseeing the strategy development process, including final approval of the new strategy. Trustees will engage with the process on an ongoing basis rather than only at final sign-off; the structure and frequency of trustee check-ins will be agreed with the appointed provider at a kick-off session (see Section 4.7).
- **Current TPCT Regional Partners:** Six regional partners have received funding from TNLCF. They are an important route into local communities and relationships, and will be engaged throughout the process, consistent with their existing agreements with TPCT. The degree and nature of that involvement, including in relation to regional convenings, will be worked through with the appointed provider at the kick-off session, and may vary between regions. This will take into account the capacity of the regional partners.
- **Strategy Development Partner:** Accountable for managing planning and delivery of all elements of the commission to a high standard, including designing recruitment and engagement approaches that reach a genuinely broad and representative range of voices across each region.

4.2 Discovery Phase

Before, and alongside, the regional convenings and digital engagement, the provider should carry out a discovery phase comprising desktop research, a review of existing data (including previous grant holder and regional partner data), and stakeholder interviews. This should build a shared evidence base and set out what is already known, so that the regional convenings and digital engagement can focus on testing and building on that picture, rather than starting from a blank page.

Stakeholder interviews conducted during discovery should include, at minimum, regional partners, funders and relevant sector bodies, so that the process starts from an accurate and current understanding of the landscape. Discovery should also be used to identify any gaps in representation, for example among intersectional communities, so that these can be addressed through the design of the convenings, digital engagement and the wider stakeholder engagement mechanism (see Section 4.5).

As discovery will run concurrently with the regional convenings and digital engagement, providers should set out in their methodology how early discovery findings will still be able to inform the design of the convenings despite the overlapping schedule.

4.3 Regional Convenings

TPCT is seeking nine in-person regional convenings, one in each of the regions in which TPCT currently works. These convenings form the core of the discovery and engagement phase of the strategy development process, bringing together a range of local stakeholders to help shape the strategy.

Each of the nine regional convenings must go beyond consultation. Participants should leave with something tangible; we are asking for their time and their trust, and the session design should reflect that.

Each convening should include representation from a range of stakeholders within the TPCT network, such as:

- TPCT Board
- Current TPCT regional partners
- Global Majority communities
- Global Majority-led organisations
- Previous The Phoenix Way grant holders
- Intersectional specialists
- Funders
- Policy-makers

Providers must set out in their methodology how they will achieve broad and representative attendance at each convening, including reaching community members and organisations who may not already be connected to TPCT's existing networks.

4.4 Digital Engagement

Alongside the regional convenings, the provider should run a programme of digital engagement, including surveys, polls and other online engagement tools, throughout the discovery and convening phases (see Section 6). This provides an additional route for people who are unable to attend an in-person convening, including those in more rural or dispersed areas, to contribute to the strategy.

Providers should set out in their methodology how digital engagement will be designed and promoted so that it reaches a genuinely wide range of people, including those who are less digitally engaged, for

example through partner-supported or offline alternatives, so that it complements rather than replaces the in-person engagement of the convenings.

4.5 Stakeholder Engagement and Playback

Providers should set out in their methodology how they will test emerging questions, language and findings with a range of stakeholders throughout the commission, and how they will play back what has been heard so that participants can see how their input has shaped the process (see Section 3). This could take the form of a standing reference group meeting at a regular interval, or another mechanism proposed by the provider; TPCT is open to the provider's own approach, informed by their experience of similar commissions.

Whatever mechanism is proposed should draw on regional partners, intersectional specialists and other key stakeholders, and should include voices representing future generations, for example young people. No single partner organisation, or region-specific relationship, should dominate its composition or influence. Providers should also set out how they will connect with other organisations and institutions in each region, beyond the existing Regional Partners to test emerging findings and build a fuller picture of community perspectives.

Whatever approach is proposed should include clear guardrails, so that testing and playback remain constructive and stay within the process timeline, while still ensuring that the input gathered is taken seriously and reflected in the record of what was heard, understood and decided.

Intersectional specialists (to be identified with TPCT) should be represented from the outset, with a funded role in the process. The costs for this should be included in the overall proposed price.

The precise mechanics of this engagement, including review points, will be finalised with the appointed provider and trustees at the kickoff session (see Section 4.7), rather than fixed in advance.

4.6 Final Strategy Framework

The final strategy framework should articulate two linked horizons:

- A long-term vision, framed as a hopeful, aspirational direction of travel rather than a fixed commitment, linked to legacy, stewardship and community wealth building, including future ambitions around land and assets. This is a direction of travel, not a settled position, and the framework should be able to hold that ambition without overstating current capacity to deliver it.
- A medium-term strategy covering a three-to-five year horizon, providing genuine direction without being fully prescriptive about delivery, structured so that the incoming Chief Executive and team can operationalise it and retain flexibility over how the organisation is structured and run.

The framework should also identify a small number of priority actions for year one of implementation, agreed with the incoming Chief Executive during the process, so that delivery is not delayed while a new leadership team spends its first months building an implementation plan from scratch.

The framework should cover: refined vision, mission and values with definitions; mission pillars; strategic goals per pillar; and delivery approach. It should also include recommendations for strategy implementation.

The exact output format will be agreed at the Trustee kick-off meeting.

4.7 Trustee Involvement and Interim Check-ins

Regular contact and check-ins with trustees throughout the process are a non-negotiable feature of this commission.

The precise structure of these check-ins, including format, frequency and the balance between trustee capacity and the need for the Board to lead and direct the work, will be agreed at a kick-off session with

trustees of around half a day, following contract award. This is deliberately left open in this specification so that the structure reflects the appointed provider's proposed approach, informed by their experience of similar commissions, rather than being fixed before a provider is in place.

5. Budget

Indicative budget: £100,000 (plus VAT where applicable). It is inclusive of all costs: provider fees, participant expenses and compensation, and funded intersectional partner roles.

Providers will be asked to submit a detailed cost breakdown. The commissioning panel will quality-assure bids for value and rigour.

6. Indicative Timeline

The timeline below reflects an indicative timeframe, which will be confirmed at the kick-off meeting with the selected supplier.

Phase	Timing/ Deadline	Key Activities
Procurement published	Early July 2026	Open tender published; provider briefing webinar held. (6-week tender period)
Prospective supplier webinar	23 July 2026 11.45 - 12.30	Online briefing for interested providers (see Section 8.1).
EOI deadline	31 July 2026 at 5pm	Prospective suppliers confirm they will submit a proposal.
Full proposal submission deadline	24 August 2026 at 9am	Written submissions due (see Section 8.2).
Assessment	Late August 2026	Shortlisting.
Interviews	3 & 4 September 2026	Including values-based interview questions with shortlisted providers.
Commission confirmed	Mid-September 2026	Contract awarded; onboarding begins.
Trustee kick-off session (Leeds)	28 September 2026	Kick-off session with trustees (see Section 4.7).
Discovery phase	October–December 2026	Desktop research; data review; stakeholder interviews.
Regional convenings (9 roadshows)	October–December 2026	In-person events across all nine regions.
Digital engagement	October–December 2026	Surveys, polls and online tools running in parallel (see Section 4.4).
Analysis, synthesis & draft framework	January/February 2027	Findings synthesised; draft strategy developed.

Board sign-off	February/March 2027	Strategy approved by the Board.
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The Board has agreed that this timeline is indicative and may need to flex, particularly if the level of participation agreed for this process requires more time than currently allowed. It should not be treated as fixed.

7. Provider Requirements

7.1 Essential Criteria

- Track record in participatory strategy development with complex, multi-stakeholder organisations, demonstrating the ability to hold competing perspectives and produce frameworks that are both rigorous and genuinely co-produced.
- Demonstrable experience of community engagement at scale, including with those who are often less represented and non-digitally-engaged communities.
- A demonstrable understanding of anti-racist practice: how racism and oppression operate structurally and institutionally, and how that understanding shapes community engagement design.
- Experience working with Global Majority communities and/or in racial justice and social justice contexts is essential. General diversity, equity and inclusion experience alone will not meet this requirement. We would particularly welcome bids from Global Majority-led organisations.
- The ability to navigate complex power dynamics, competing perspectives and emotionally charged stakeholder relationships with sensitivity, nuance and skill.
- Capacity to deliver across nine regions over a concentrated period. Providers should demonstrate clearly how they will manage this, whether as a single organisation or a partnership.
- Experience with digital engagement and mapping tools (see Section 4.4).
- No conflicts of interest that would compromise the independence or integrity of the work. Organisations that currently have funding from TPCT are not eligible to bid, due to a conflict of interest.
- If submitting as a partnership bid: partners must have an established working relationship and clearly articulated complementary strengths. Partnership and consortium bids are actively encouraged, particularly where this allows smaller or Global Majority-led organisations, who may not hold every required skill in-house, to bid competitively. A single lead organisation must hold the contract and be accountable for its delivery.
- Familiarity with the philanthropic and grant-making landscape in the UK.
- Experience engaging funders, government stakeholders and community infrastructure organisations.

8. Application Process

The procurement process will involve two stages: a written submission and a values-based interview.

8.1 Pre-application

Interested providers can attend an online briefing webinar on 23 July 2026, covering TPCT's vision for the process, what is being looked for in a partner, and the detail of this specification. The webinar will be recorded, and the recording made available to those unable to attend live. You can register [here](#).

Interested providers should then confirm their intention to submit a proposal via a short, informal Expression of Interest (EOI) by 31 July 2026 at 5pm using [this link](#). Note that the EOI is not scored. It is to give TPCT an indication of levels of interest in the tender.

Following the Expression of Interest, providers who would like an informal conversation to help them understand TPCT or navigate the specification, particularly smaller or Global Majority-led organisations, can request one. These conversations with a Trustee will be offered on request rather than as a default part of the process. Contact info@phoenix-trust.co.uk.

8.2 Written Submission

Providers should submit:

- a methodology and approach covering how each element of the scope will be delivered
- evidence of relevant track record related to the criteria
- a team overview including any partnership arrangements
- a detailed budget breakdown
- a brief written response to each of the values-based questions in Section 8.3 below
- two referees.

8.3 Values-based Assessment Questions

Providers are asked to respond to all four questions as part of their written submission and should expect to discuss these further at interview. The response to each question should be no longer than 500 words.

1. Radical trust and transparency (500 words max)

Can you give an example of a time you have had to hold a difficult tension between transparency with a client and managing a sensitive stakeholder relationship? How did you navigate that, and how did you keep people informed of what you had heard and what you decided as a result?

2. Learning over perfection (500 words max)

Tell us about a piece of work that went wrong, or where the client relationship became challenging. What happened, and what learnings did you take from it?

3. Holding space for multiple perspectives (500 words max)

How do you support a group of people, including those with a direct stake in the outcome, to surface a range of views, including dissenting ones, when there is no consensus in the room?

4. Values in practice (500 words max)

When you talk about redistributing power, anti-racist practice or community-led decision making in your work, what does that actually look like in delivery? What are the trade-offs you have had to make?

8.4 Interview Panel

Shortlisted providers will be invited to interview with an assessment panel. Prior experience and methodology are threshold criteria. The interview will include values-based questions to help us decide whether a provider is the right fit.

8.5 Submission Details

Submit responses as outlined in Section 8.2 and 8.3 to info@phoenix-trust.co.uk by 24 August 9am. Note, submissions that do not address the values-based questions will not be taken forward to interview.

For queries about this specification prior to submission, please contact info@phoenix-trust.co.uk.

9. Additional Notes

9.1 Anonymous Feedback

The process should include a mechanism for anonymous feedback from participants in the regional convenings and the wider stakeholder engagement process (see Section 4.5). Providers should set out in their methodology how they will collect and respond to this feedback.

9.2 Data and CRM

Providers will be expected to work within TPCT's data governance framework and to respect the data sharing arrangements in place between TPCT, TPCT regional partners, and TNLCF. A signed data sharing agreement with the provider will be required as part of the contract.